

Aster Group is the overarching brand name of Aster Group Ltd and all of its subsidiaries.

1 Scope

- 1.1 This policy outlines Aster's approach to managing our empty homes. An empty home is defined as a property that is currently empty, and a tenancy or licence has ended, but a new one has not begun, as well as new, unsold shared ownership properties.
- 1.2 This policy applies to all rental properties owned or managed by Aster Group.
- 1.3 This policy aims to minimise the time a home is empty, maximise value for money, meet customer expectations and ensure we meet statutory requirements.
- 1.4 Empty homes may occur when:
 - A tenancy is terminated by the customer.
 - A property is abandoned, and Aster has taken steps to end the tenancy.
 - An eviction has occurred, and we have taken back possession of the property.
 - A licence is ended, and the property is returned to us.
 - A property has been temporarily or permanently vacated (decanted).
 - A tenant has passed away and there are no succession rights so the tenancy must be brought to an end.
 - A new property has been built but not yet purchased or rented.
- 1.5 This policy is applied in conjunction with our Lettings Policy, which aims to ensure the best use of the property by letting to the most suitable applicant, and the Lettable Standard which sets the specific requirements that our homes must meet before they are ready to let. There may be different standards depending on the type of property, e.g. independent living, general needs, or private rent properties.

2 Policy Statement

- 2.1 We will ensure we minimise loss of rental income as a result of empty homes.
- 2.2 We will advise customers of their responsibilities when ending their tenancy, as set out in their agreement, through written communication and a pre-termination inspection. This inspection will identify any necessary work to avoid recharges. This includes unauthorised alterations. The customer can either complete the work to the required standard themselves or choose to have Aster carry it out, in which case they will be recharged the cost. Properties must be returned in the expected condition to allow repairs during the void period.
- 2.3 Customers transferring within Aster's stock will usually only be allowed to move once their current property has passed inspection, unless exceptional circumstances apply. If a home is not left empty, and in a reasonable condition, we reserve the right to complete the required work and recharge the outgoing tenant in line with our Recharge Policy, excluding any rent loss during the void period.
- 2.4 We will conduct a post- works inspection prior to the property being made available to the customer.

- 2.5 We will ensure properties meet our Lettable Standard before customers move in, or if preferred, provided there are no health and safety concerns, customers are able to move in, and we will advise them when the work on the property will be completed.
- 2.6 Repair works that are due to reasonable wear and tear will not be rechargeable.
- 2.7 We will ensure customers who have been allocated the empty home are kept fully informed about the progress of works required and their expected move in date, which may be subject to change.
- 2.8 When a home becomes empty, we may consider an options appraisal or disposal, which reviews current and future performance of properties before commencing any essential works and looking to re-let. Our Strategic Asset Management Team manages identifying which properties should be flagged as part of our disposal programme.
- 2.9 We will comply with our insurance requirements if works are required to an empty home, and/or a home is empty for an extended amount of time.
- 2.10 If a customer is unhappy with how we have dealt with our empty homes, including how a property has been re-let, we will look to resolve the issue in line with our Complaints Policy.
- 2.11 The Empty Homes Team and Lettings Team together with other colleagues are responsible for the implementation of this policy.
- 2.12 We are committed to inclusivity and accessibility and will endeavour to provide our communication and policies in accessible formats and in other languages when requested or required.

3 Monitoring and Review

- 3.1 In reviewing this Empty Homes Policy, we consulted with involved customers who have expressed an interest in giving us their views on customer service policies, as well as colleagues who are involved in the lettings and management of our homes.
- 3.2 Policy overview sessions will be delivered to relevant teams following implementation of this policy to ensure the content and responsibilities are understood.
- 3.3 This policy will be monitored through colleague one-to-ones and Operational Performance Indicators including average days to re-let, refusals & rejections, termination reasons, % of first offers taken, long term void monitoring (over 90 days) and void rent loss. Shared Ownership properties that have been void / unreserved over 26 weeks are monitored and reported to the Group Investment and Assets Panel each month.
- 3.4 The policy will be reviewed every 3 years as standard, unless a change in legislation, regulation or business need prompts an earlier review.
- 3.5 We will monitor customer feedback and lessons learnt from complaints.

4 Related Policies and Procedures

This Policy, in conjunction with associated documents outlined below, sets out Aster Group's approach to meeting the requirements outlined by the RSH Tenancy Standard 2024.

Documents available to Aster Group colleagues and in the public domain

- 4.1 Aids & Adaptations Policy
- 4.2 Asbestos Policy
- 4.3 Complaints Policy
- 4.4 Damp, Mould and Condensation Policy
- 4.5 Gas, Oil and Solid Fuel Policy
- 4.6 Neighbourhood Management Policy
- 4.7 Probity and Integrity Policy
- 4.8 Repairs and Maintenance Policy
- 4.9 Section 20 Policy
- 4.10 Tenancy Policy
- 4.11 Temporary Rehousing Policy
- 4.12 Vulnerability Policy

Documents available to Aster Group colleagues only

- 4.13 Aids & Adaptations Procedure
- 4.14 Complaints Procedure
- 4.15 Customer Accounts Procedure
- 4.16 Damp, Mould and Condensation Procedure
- 4.17 Customer Accounts Procedure
- 4.18 Financial Wellbeing Service Procedure
- 4.19 Fire Management Procedure
- 4.20 Gas, Oil, and Solid Fuel Procedure
- 4.21 Group Health & Safety Policy
- 4.22 Lettable Standard
- 4.23 Lettings Policy & Procedure
- 4.24 Mutual Exchange Procedure
- 4.25 Neighbourhood Inspection Procedure
- 4.26 Neighbourhood Inspection Repairs Reporting Procedure
- 4.27 Recharge Policy & Procedure
- 4.28 Section 20 Procedure
- 4.29 Section 21 Procedure
- 4.30 The Starter Tenancy Procedure
- 4.31 Tenancy Check Procedure
- 4.32 Tenancy Policy and Procedure
- 4.33 Temporary Rehousing Policy & Procedure
- 4.34 Under-Occupancy and Overcrowding Guidance
- 4.35 Water Safety Management Procedure

5 Governance			
Effective From:	21/10/2025	Expires:	20/10/2028
Policy Owner:	Regional Operations Director		
Policy Author:	Policy Officer		
Approved by:	<i>Customer Services Operational Leadership Team</i>		
Scheme of Delegation Reference:	R055.13	Version Number:	V3.00